

Tackling the TORMENT

As doctors uncover new truths about the brain, headache clinics, new drugs and treatments mushroom. The revolution in treating extreme headaches has just started.

By Damayanti Datta

Thanks to a near-daily tidal wave of headaches, Kavita Raj has not watched a movie or listened to music for the last three years. Raj's suffering is hellish: her vision gets hijacked by a wall of shimmering light, her sense of smell and hearing become unbearably acute, and a mind-numbing, vomit-inducing headache takes over. Despite popping 10 to 12 tablets a day, stabbing pains in the head have become this 30-year-old's destiny. "There's no choice but to retreat to a darkened bedroom and wait, often for days, until the agony passes," says the Delhi gynaecologist.

Raj is not alone. September was labelled World Headache Month, and not without reason. According to the World Health Organization (WHO), the burden of headache is rising. "Extreme headaches rank among the most disabling, the most misunderstood, the most misdiagnosed and the most mismanaged of disorders in the world," says Dr K. Ravishankar, who started the first Headache and Migraine clinics at

18%

WOMEN, NEARLY 10% MEN AND ABOUT 6% CHILDREN SUFFER FROM EXTREME HEADACHES.

33%

SUFFERERS CONSULT A DOCTOR. THE REST DO THEIR OWN PATCHWORK CURES WITH PAINKILLERS.